IDEA School Router – Image and Automated Flashing

One OpenWrt image for every Cudy WR3000S, flashed and checked by a script

Proposal · Status: Approved by Koen 2026-10-15

IDEA - offline school computing. Prepared for Koen Swings's team.
No real passwords, keys or tokens are included; values in <ANGLE BRACKETS> are placeholders.

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Author: Steve (Lead Bot) **Date:** 2026-10-15 **Status:** Approved by Koen 2026-10-15. Decisions D1–D11 closed in section 10. Updated 2026-10-15: Engine count not fixed (a school starts with 1 and adds more), Starlink chapter (section 12); D10–D11 closed same day.

1. Problem

Today a school router is set up by hand, following section 3 of the school server install manual (`docs/manuals/install/install-manual-school-server/`): two firmware uploads in a browser, a calibration backup, `school-router-setup.sh`, then Tailscale by hand with the auth key typed in. That is about an hour per router, easy to get wrong, and every router ends up slightly different.

Koen's requirements (15 October 2026):

- An **IDEA-specific OpenWrt image**, built with the official OpenWrt **Image Builder** plus a **uci-defaults first-boot script**. It comes up with Tailscale and the `IDEA` Wi-Fi already working.
- Default passwords follow the IDEA convention `<name>911!`: Wi-Fi `IDEA` uses `idea911!`, the router login is `root` / `admin911!`.
- An **automated flashing procedure**: first flash from Cudy stock firmware through Cudy's intermediate OpenWrt image, then `sysupgrade` to the IDEA image. It should be scripted from a laptop or Pi over Ethernet, and later become a **flash station** in the Console/Engine.
- Steve's own suggestions for further customisation.

Koen has bought Cudy WR3000S routers and collects them on 16 October. Their hardware revision is not known yet.

2. What stays the same (school design of 13–14 October)

This proposal changes **how** the router gets its settings, not **what** they are. The existing design stays:

- Every school uses the **same addresses**: router `10.42.0.1`, Engines on `10.42.0.0/24`, students on Wi-Fi `10.42.1.0/24`, teachers on `10.42.2.0/24`. There are no school numbers.
- **One or more PoE Pi 5 Engines** behind the Cudy. The number is **not fixed**: a school starts with **1** and can add or remove Engines at any time. Nothing in the router depends on how many Engines there are. **Starlink** in bypass mode on the Cudy WAN port (section 12).
- Wi-Fi **`IDEA`** (students) reaches the Pis only, **never** the WAN. Client isolation is on.
- Wi-Fi **`IDEA-Teachers`** gets internet through **one** firewall rule, `Teachers-Internet`, which is off by default and can be switched on and off (later from the Console).
- **Tailscale is always on** on the router and the Pis, with the one fleet tag `tag:idea` and one fleet auth key. There are no per-school keys or tags. ACL: admins → `tag:idea`; `tag:idea` reaches nothing.
- The router's DNS is the **fallback for `idea.local`** (mDNS on the Engines is the main path).
- Pis **move between schools without admin work**. Pis get **sticker names** (two words, for example `brave-otter`).

The image simply bakes `school-router-setup.sh` (manual Appendix A) and `router-tailscale-zone.sh` (A.2) into the first boot, so the manual and the image share one source of truth.

3. The hardware: Cudy WR3000S v1 (checked on the web, 15 October 2026)

Fact	Value	Source
OpenWrt support	Yes, **WR3000S v1**, since **24.10.0**; current stable **25.12.5**	[1], [3], [4]
SoC / RAM / flash	MediaTek **MT7981B**, 2 × 1.3 GHz, **256 MB RAM**, **128 MB SPI-NAND**	[1], [5]
Ports	5 × 1 GbE (1 WAN, 4 LAN), no 2.5 GbE, no USB	[1]
Wi-Fi	MT7981 + MT7976CN, 2.4 GHz 2×2 ax, 5 GHz ax	[1]
Power	12 V DC barrel	[1]
OpenWrt target / profile	`mediatek/filogic`, profile `cudy_wr3000s-v1`	[3], [4]
Official sysupgrade image	`openwrt-25.12.5-mediatek-filogic-cudy_wr3000s-v1-squashfs-sysupgrade.bin`, SHA-256 `b0a26c80…aa8b2`	[4]
Image Builder	`openwrt-imagebuilder-25.12.5-mediatek-filogic.Linux-x86_64.tar.zst`	[6]
Tailscale package	`tailscale-1.102.3-r1.apk`, **10.5 MB** compressed (aarch64_cortex-a53)	[7]
24.10 branch	still maintained, latest **24.10.8**	[3]

Does Tailscale fit? Yes, easily. On a 128 MB NAND the wiki reports about 48 MiB free overlay on the stock OpenWrt image [1]. In our image Tailscale is **inside the squashfs** (compressed, read-only), so it does not use the overlay at all; the 10.5 MB package is a fraction of the ~100 MB UBI space. The `tailscaled` process uses about 30–50 MB of RAM at runtime, which fits in 256 MB next to dnsmasq, hostapd and LuCI. We will measure free RAM in the test plan (section 9) rather than trust these numbers.

Release choice: build on **25.12.5**, the release the install manual already uses. 25.12 uses `apk` instead of `opkg`; the Image Builder hides this difference. 24.10.8 is the fallback if 25.12 shows a problem on this device.

3.1 Which revision did Koen get? (do this tomorrow)

From the label (bottom of the router):

1. Model must read **WR3000S** and hardware version **V1.x**. WR3000, WR3000H, WR3000E and WR3000P are other devices with other images. Anything other than WR3000S V1 → stop.
2. Read the **serial number**. Serials that start with `S000` carry the production year and week (YYWW) in characters 9–12 [1]. Example: `S000xxxx2611xxxxx` → 2026, week 11.

3. **Week 2543 or later** (from November 2025) means the **new ESMT F50L1G41LC flash chip** [1], [2]. Those units need the **new** Cudy intermediate image (20251119 build) and OpenWrt 24.10.5 or later. 25.12.5 qualifies. Since Koen bought them in 2026, assume the new chip.

From the stock web UI (`http://192.168.10.1` or `http://cudy.net`, laptop on a LAN port):

- **Status / System** (or the footer) shows model, **hardware version** and **firmware version**.
- Note the firmware version. Recent stock (2.4.6 and later) first asks to create an admin password [1]. Never downgrade stock to 2.3.x or older on a new-flash unit [2].

From the intermediate image (the script does this automatically, section 6): over SSH the flash station reads `/proc/mtd`, `dmesg | grep -i spi-nand` (shows the chip name) and the board name, and refuses to go on if the board is not `cudy,wr3000s-v1`.

4. The IDEA router image

4.1 How it is built

A script in the repo, `tools/router-image/build.sh`, runs the official Image Builder (no compiling, 2–3 minutes):

```
make image PROFILE=cudy_wr3000s-v1 \
  PACKAGES="luci luci-ssl tailscale umdns luci-i18n-base-en -wpad-basic-mbedtls wpad-mbedtls \
            luci-app-sqm sqm-scripts prometheus-node-exporter-lua ..." \
  FILES=files/ EXTRA_IMAGE_NAME=idea-<version>
```

- `files/` holds the IDEA overlay: `/etc/uci-defaults/90-idea-setup` (the first-boot script), `/etc/idea/version`, `/etc/sysupgrade.conf` (keep-list), the banner, and the LED/button scripts.
- The **first-boot script** is `school-router-setup.sh` turned into a uci-defaults file: it runs once at the first boot after a flash, writes all settings with `uci`, and is then deleted by OpenWrt automatically. It is **idempotent** (deletes and re-creates its own sections), so running it twice gives the same result.
- The output is **one image for every school** (no per-school values), named `idea-router-<version>-cudy_wr3000s-v1-squashfs-sysupgrade.bin`, with a `SHA256SUMS` file.
- The build pins the Image Builder by version **and SHA-256**, so the same inputs always give the same image. CI can build it; the release is attached to a GitHub release like the client image.

4.2 What the first boot sets

Area	Setting
System	Hostname = the router's **sticker name** (section 5.4), time zone `Africa/Harare` (CAT-2), LuCI in English
Login	`root` / `admin911!` (D2 decided); SSH (dropbear) on LAN and Tailscale only, not on WAN or Wi-Fi
LAN	`10.42.0.1/24`; DHCP pool `.100–.199`; `.2–.99` reserved for fixed devices

Area	Setting
Wi-Fi	`IDEA` (psk2, `idea911!`, isolation on) → `students` `10.42.1.0/24`; `IDEA-Teachers` (psk2, `idea-teachers911!`) → `teachers` `10.42.2.0/24`; both bands; country `ZW`
Firewall	as the manual: students/teachers → only DHCP, DNS and the Engines; `Teachers-Internet` rule present, **off**
DNS	dnsmasq answers `idea.local` with the live Engine addresses (section 5.2); everything else is forwarded upstream only for LAN and teachers
mDNS	`umdns` reflects mDNS between LAN and the Wi-Fi zones, as the client-browser proposal requires
Tailscale	`tailscale up --auth-key=file:… --advertise-tags=tag:idea --hostname=<sticker>`, `tailscale0` in its own zone with **no forwarding** (unchanged from manual 3.7)
Starlink CGNAT (D10)	Narrow exception: WAN UDP 67→68 accepted before Tailscale's `100.64.0.0/10` drop in `ts-input`, re-applied by a hotplug script when `wan` / `tailscale0` come up (section 5 item 21, Appendix D of the install manual)
Updates	none automatic; a new IDEA image is the only update (same rule as the client image)

4.3 The fleet auth key: never in git, never in the image file

This is the one real secret. The rules:

- The key is **not** in the repo and **not** in the published image. If it were in the image, anyone who downloads an image could join the IDEA tailnet as `tag:idea`.
- The flash station puts it on the router **after** the IDEA image has booted, over SSH on the LAN cable: `scp` to `/tmp/tskey` (RAM only), `tailscale up --auth-key=file:/tmp/tskey`, then `rm`. It never appears on a command line or in a log.
- The key itself: **reusable, pre-authorised, tagged `tag:idea`**, not ephemeral (an ephemeral router would vanish from the tailnet when it is offline for a while, for example during a power cut). Tagged devices have key expiry off by default, so the router stays on after the key expires [8].
- The flash station reads it from `~/.config/idea-router/fleet-authkey` (mode 600), the same pattern as the client image's `secrets-test.env`. Rotating the key does not touch any router already enrolled.
- **Alternative (D4):** bake the key into a private build for a field installer who has no flash station. Then the built file itself is a secret and must never be uploaded to a release.

The Wi-Fi and root passwords are **not** secret by design (Koen, 15 October: easy, well-known defaults; teachers can change them). They may be in the repo.

5. Customisation suggestions (evaluated)

Recommended now marks what I propose for the first image. "Later" means a separate step.

#	Idea	Verdict	Why / how
1	Fixed LAN IP `10.42.0.1` + DHCP pool	**Now**	Already the design.
2	DHCP reservations for the Engines	**Now, changed**	MAC reservations break "Pis move without admin" and need one entry per Engine. Instead every Engine sends DHCP vendor class `idea-engine`; dnsmasq gives that class addresses from `.2–.9`, however many Engines there are (section 5.1).
3	`idea.local` → Engines in router DNS	**Now**	A dnsmasq lease script keeps `idea.local` = the live Engine leases (section 5.2).
4	Sticker hostname for the router	**Now**	Same word list as the Pis; used for hostname and Tailscale name (section 5.4).
5	Firewall split students/ teachers	**Now**	Already the design; image just bakes it in.
6	Captive/landing page → `idea.local`	**Now, light**	DNS hijack only: on `IDEA` every unknown name resolves to the router, which redirects HTTP to `http://idea.local`. Phones then show "sign in to network" and open the IDEA start page. No captive-portal package.
7	No auto-update	**Now**	No `attendedsysupgrade`, no cron updates. New image = update.
8	NTP without internet	**Now**	Router serves NTP to LAN/Wi-Fi (`sysntpd` server on). Upstream: pool via Starlink when up, and the Engines as peers. No RTC on either side, so we accept "time is right once Starlink was up once".
9	LuCI language	**Now**	English only (smaller, matches manuals). Add `luci-i18n-base-fr` etc. later per country.
10	Factory-reset behaviour	**Now**	The IDEA defaults live in the **squashfs** (uci-defaults), so the reset button / `firstboot` gives back the **IDEA** router, not plain OpenWrt. Only the Tailscale identity is lost (section 5.5).
11	Sysupgrade keep-list	**Now**	`/etc/sysupgrade.conf` keeps `/etc/tailscale/` (identity), `/etc/idea/` (sticker name, school-local changes). An image upgrade keeps the router on the tailnet with the same name.
12	Remote fleet monitoring over Tailscale	**Now**	`prometheus-node-exporter-lua` (or a tiny `/cgi-bin/idea-health` JSON) on the tailscale zone only. Atlas's fleet-health check reads it: uptime, WAN up, Starlink reachable, clients per SSID, free RAM. Needs one ACL line: admins → `tag:idea:9100` is already covered by admins → `tag:idea`.
13	Backup/restore config	**Now, small**	The flash station stores `sysupgrade -b` backups + the Factory/ bdinfo calibration dump per serial in the IDEA backup area, not in git.

#	Idea	Verdict	Why / how
14	LED / button behaviour	**Now, small**	Status LED: blink while first boot runs, solid when Tailscale is up, slow blink when WAN is down. Reset button: short press = reboot, 10 s = IDEA factory reset (OpenWrt default). WPS button: **disabled** (WPS bypasses the Wi-Fi password).
15	Logging	**Now**	Logs in RAM (OpenWrt default, protects the NAND), 512 KB ring; Atlas pulls `logread` over Tailscale when needed. No remote syslog yet.
16	Bandwidth limits	**Later**	SQM (`cake`) on WAN only matters once teachers have internet. Package in the image, **off** by default.
17	Content filtering on teacher Wi-Fi	**Later (D6)**	Cheap option: dnsmasq forwards teacher DNS to a filtering resolver (e.g. a family DNS service) and blocks DoH/DoT. Real filtering needs policy decisions first.
18	Starlink WAN (section 12) + 4G fallback	**Later, optional school add-on (D7)**	WR3000S has **no USB**, so 4G needs an external 4G router/ hotspot on a LAN port as a second WAN, with `mwan3`. A school may buy and fund this itself; the IDEA project never funds 4G connections.
21	Starlink CGNAT DHCP exception (D10)	**Now**	Image installs a hotplug that inserts `nft insert rule ip filter ts-input iifname "wan" udp sport 67 udp dport 68 counter accept` before Tailscale's CGNAT drop, so Starlink DHCP renewals are not dropped [19], [20]. Same script as the install manual Appendix D.
19	Expose a Tailscale subnet route	**No**	Contradicts "tag:idea reaches nothing / no subnet routes", and every school has the same `10.42.0.0/24`, so routes would collide. Admins reach each device directly.
20	Per-school passwords	**No**	Koen chose the `<name>911!` defaults.

5.1 Engines get fixed addresses without MAC reservations

Each Engine sets DHCP option 60 (vendor class) to `idea-engine` (one line in its NetworkManager connection, done by the Engine installer). The router has:

```
dhcp-vendorclass=set:engine,idea-engine
dhcp-range=tag:engine,10.42.0.2,10.42.0.9,12h
```

So **every** Engine at a school, whether there is 1 or several, gets an address in `.2–.9`, with no per-Pi configuration. Adding another Engine later needs no router change either. The pool holds **8 Engines**; if a school ever needs more than 8, widening the range (and the matching firewall range) is a one-line image change. The firewall allows students and teachers to the whole `10.42.0.2–10.42.0.9` range, never to individual Engine addresses, so the rules do not change when Engines come and go. This replaces the `PI1_MAC` / `PI2_MAC` fields in the manual. (The reserved switch address `.4` moves to `.10`.) Which Engine gets which address is not fixed and does not matter: clients use `idea.local` or a sticker name, not an IP.

5.2 `idea.local` in the router DNS

A dnsmasq `dhcp-script` writes the current Engine leases into `/tmp/hosts/idea` (`10.42.0.x idea.local`) and reloads dnsmasq on every lease change. It lists **all** live Engine leases (1 to 8 lines), so `idea.local` works the same with one Engine or many. When an Engine is switched off, its lease ages out and only the Engines still on are answered; with a single Engine, `idea.local` simply points at that one. This matches the takeover design (Axle, #203): mDNS from the holder is primary, the router is the backup.

5.3 First boot flow

1. Flash station writes the IDEA image (section 6).
2. First boot: `90-idea-setup` runs, sets everything in 4.2, LED blinks.
3. Flash station sends the sticker name and the fleet auth key over SSH; the router joins Tailscale; LED solid.
4. Flash station runs the self-test (section 9.1) and prints the sticker label.

5.4 Router sticker name

The flash station picks a two-word name from the same word list as the Pis (`provision-fleet.sh … auto`), checks it is unused in the tailnet, writes it to `/etc/idea/sticker` and prints a label with: sticker name, `IDEA` Wi-Fi / `idea911!`, `http://10.42.0.1` and the Cudy serial. The name is kept across upgrades (keep-list) and across a factory reset only if we choose to (D5).

5.5 What a factory reset does

The reset gives back the IDEA defaults (Wi-Fi, firewall, `10.42.0.1`), so a school never ends up with an open router. It also erases the Tailscale identity, so the router is **off the tailnet** until someone re-enrols it. Options for D5: (a) accept this: a local helper calls support, we re-enrol over the LAN with the flash station or a Pi; (b) let an Engine on the LAN re-enrol the router automatically (the Engine has a Tailscale identity and could push the key over SSH). I recommend (a) for now and (b) as part of the Console flash station.

6. Automated flashing

6.1 Two steps, because Cudy stock only accepts Cudy-signed firmware

```
Cudy stock (192.168.10.1)  --web upload-->  Cudy intermediate OpenWrt (192.168.1.1, SSH root, no password)
      --scp + sysupgrade -n-->  IDEA image (10.42.0.1)  --SSH: sticker + auth key + self-test--> done
```

- **Step 1 (stock → intermediate)** is a web form in Cudy's UI. It is the only step that is not plain SSH. The script `idea-router-flash` automates it with HTTP requests the way the browser does (login, upload, confirm) for the stock version we find tomorrow; if Cudy's UI changes, the script falls back to telling the operator "upload this file in the browser now"

and waits for `192.168.1.1` to answer. **This needs testing on the real router before we rely on it.**

- The intermediate image must be the **20251119 build** for new-flash units, MD5 `403e276f…1a137`, size 14,945,872 bytes [1], [2]. The script checks both before uploading. The WR3000H/P files have almost the same names.
- **Step 2 (intermediate → IDEA)**: the script checks the board name, dumps `Factory` and `bdinfo` (`/dev/mtd2`, `/dev/mtd3`) with SHA-256 check [1], then `scp -O` the IDEA image and `sysupgrade -n`. Never the `ubootmod` image (only a serial cable can undo it [1]).
- **Re-flashing an IDEA router** later skips step 1: `sysupgrade` (keeping settings) to the new IDEA version.

6.2 Where it runs

- **Phase 1 (now):** `tools/router-image/idea-router-flash` runs on a Linux laptop or a Pi with one Ethernet cable into the Cudy's LAN2. It needs only `ssh`, `scp`, `curl`, `sha256sum`. Koen or Atlas runs it; output is one line per step plus a final PASS/FAIL report.
- **Phase 2:** the same script on an **Engine as flash station** (Console "Flash router" button), using a spare Ethernet port or a USB-Ethernet adapter so the school LAN is not disturbed. The fleet key then stays on the Engine and never touches a laptop.
- **Batch:** one router at a time per cable. All routers start on the same addresses, so two at once would collide.

6.3 Recovery

If a router does not come back: Cudy's TFTP recovery (`recovery.bin` served on `192.168.1.88`, reset held at power-on) [9]. The script prints these steps when a flash times out. The Factory/bdinfo dump from step 2 restores calibration if a later accident wipes it.

7. Repo layout

```
tools/router-image/
  build.sh                     # Image Builder wrapper, pinned version + SHA-256
  packages.txt                 # package list
  files/etc/uci-defaults/90-idea-setup
  files/etc/sysupgrade.conf
  files/etc/idea/...           # version, lease script, LED/button hotplug
  idea-router-flash            # flash station script (stock -> intermediate -> IDEA -> enrol ->
test)
  test/                        # self-test + fw4 render test (no hardware)
```

`docs/manuals/install/scripts/school-router-setup.sh` becomes a thin wrapper that runs the same setup file, so the manual (for a router flashed by hand) and the image can never drift apart.

8. Changes to the manuals

- School server install manual, section 2–3: replace the hand flashing and `school-router-setup.sh` steps with "plug in the pre-flashed IDEA router, check the sticker", and move the hand procedure to an appendix.
- Section 5: drop the Pi MAC reservations (5.1 above).
- Teacher tutorial: the router Wi-Fi names and the `idea911!` / `idea-teachers911!` defaults, and how to change them in LuCI.

9. Test plan

9.1 Automatic self-test after each flash (the script runs it)

`/etc/idea/version` matches; `uci show` matches the expected settings; `fw4 print` contains no students→wan path; both SSIDs up on both bands; `tailscale status` online with `tag:idea`; `nslookup idea.local 10.42.0.1`; free RAM and overlay space logged.

9.2 Acceptance on the first real router (Atlas, with Koen)

- Label/revision and flash chip recorded; full flash from stock with the script, twice (once with a factory reset between).
- Phone on `IDEA`: gets `10.42.1.x`, opens `http://idea.local`, **cannot** reach the internet or the router's LuCI.
- Laptop on `IDEA-Teachers`: no internet; switch `Teachers-Internet` on → internet; off → none.
- Engine count: start with **1** Engine (gets an address in `.2–.9`, `idea.local` answers it), add further Engines one by one without any router change; each gets `.2–.9` without MAC config and appears in `idea.local`. Switch them off one by one → `idea.local` answers only the live ones.
- Starlink: WAN gets a `100.64.x.x` lease, Tailscale online, the lease **renews** over 24 h (section 12.3, D10 exception in place); unplug Starlink → students/teachers keep the Console, `idea.local` and all Apps.
- Move an Engine to a "second school" (a second flashed router): works with no change.
- Factory reset button → IDEA defaults back; Tailscale re-enrol works.
- Sysupgrade to a newer IDEA build → same sticker name and tailnet identity.
- 24 h soak with 30 Wi-Fi clients: free RAM stays above 60 MB with Tailscale running.

10. Decisions (closed, 15 October 2026)

Koen approved all recommendations D1–D9 as recommended (chat, 15 October 2026). D7 clarified: 4G is only an optional add-on a school may buy and fund itself; the IDEA project never funds 4G connections. Later the same day Koen closed D10 and D11 (chat): D10 option (a), D11 the IDEA project owns and pays for Starlink.

#	Question	Decision
D1	OpenWrt base: 25.12.5 (current, matches manual) or 24.10.8 (older branch)?	**25.12.5** (as recommended)
D2	Router login: `root` / `admin911!` (LuCI and SSH on LAN), SSH over Tailscale key-only?	**Yes** (as recommended): password on the LAN, keys remotely
D3	Teacher Wi-Fi password: `idea-teachers911!` (fits the `<name>911!` convention)?	**Yes** (as recommended)
D4	Auth key: injected by the flash station after first boot (never in an image), or a private image with the key baked in?	**Inject** (as recommended)
D5	After a factory reset: re-enrol by hand (a), or automatically from an Engine (b)?	**(a) now, (b) with the Console flash station** (as recommended)
D6	Teacher content filtering: none, filtering DNS resolver, or later?	**Later**, once teacher internet is in use (as recommended)
D7	4G fallback: external 4G router/hotspot as second WAN?	**Optional school add-on only.** A school may buy and fund 4G itself; the IDEA project **never** funds 4G connections. Image support (`mwan3`) later when a school asks.
D8	Engines by DHCP vendor class (no MAC reservations), firewall to `.2–.9`?	**Yes** (as recommended; one-line Engine installer change)
D9	Captive "sign in" page that opens `idea.local` on student phones?	**Yes** (as recommended)
D10	Tailscale CGNAT drop rule vs. Starlink DHCP: image exception (a) or tailnet attribute (b)?	**(a)** (as recommended): narrow WAN UDP 67→68 accept before the drop, re-applied by hotplug; verified on the first router (9.2)
D11	Starlink account and subscription: school, project, or mix?	**IDEA project** owns the account and pays the subscription

11. Work and owners

Owner	Work
Atlas (Ops)	Image build script, first-boot script, flash script, self-test; first router acceptance with Koen
Axle (Engine)	DHCP vendor class `idea-engine` in the Engine installer; flash station in the Engine (phase 2)
Pixel (Console)	"Flash router" and "Teachers internet on/off" in the Console (phase 2)
Marco (manuals)	Manual and teacher tutorial changes (section 8)

First step tomorrow: Koen reads the label (section 3.1) and sends a photo; Atlas builds the first image and flashes one router with the script while Koen watches.

12. Starlink on the router's WAN

A short chapter rather than a separate document: on the IDEA side Starlink is only "the thing on the WAN port". Facts checked on the web on 15 October 2026 (sources 11–17).

12.1 Bypass mode (in the Starlink app)

Bypass mode turns off the Starlink router's own routing and Wi-Fi so a third-party router (our Cudy) takes over [11].

1. Install the dish and the Starlink router as Starlink's own guide says, activate the account (`starlink.com/activate`), and check in the Starlink app that the dish is online and unobstructed.
2. Connect a phone to the Starlink Wi-Fi and open the **Starlink app → Settings → Bypass mode → Enable** (slide the switch, confirm) [11], [12].
3. Router 3 (Gen3): the LED turns **violet** to show bypass mode (it turns off after an hour) [11], [13].
4. Cable the Cudy (12.2) and power-cycle the Cudy once so it asks for a fresh WAN lease.

Caveats.

- Bypass **switches off the Starlink Wi-Fi completely** [11]. All Wi-Fi at the school then comes from the Cudy (`IDEA`, `IDEA-Teachers`). Do the app steps first, while the Starlink Wi-Fi still exists.
- There is **no switch to turn bypass off**: leaving bypass needs a **factory reset** of the Starlink router (reset button, paperclip) [11], [13]. After a reset the Starlink Wi-Fi comes back and the Cudy is behind a second NAT; things still work (double NAT), but redo step 2.
- The Starlink app's Wi-Fi features (client list, speed per device) no longer show school devices. The dish status and obstruction map in the app keep working.

12.2 Cabling

- **Standard kit with Router 3 (Gen3):** remove the rubber cover on the back of the Starlink router and connect one of its two Ethernet ports to the **Cudy WAN port** with a normal Cat5e/Cat6 cable. No adapter is needed [13], [14].
- **Older kit with the Gen2 router:** it has no Ethernet port; it needs the **Starlink Ethernet adapter** (Starlink shop) between the router and the dish cable, and the adapter's Ethernet port goes to the Cudy WAN [15].
- **Starlink Mini** (router built in): Ethernet from the Mini to the Cudy WAN; the official Mini cable keeps its weatherproofing [12].
- The Starlink router **stays powered and connected**: it powers the dish [14]. Never connect a switch between the Starlink power supply and the router [12].
- Nothing else from the school plugs into the Starlink router; the Engines and the PoE switch go on the Cudy LAN.

```
dish ── Starlink router (bypass) ──Ethernet── Cudy WAN │ Cudy LAN ── PoE switch ── Engines
```

12.3 What the Cudy WAN gets

- The Cudy WAN is a plain **DHCP client** (OpenWrt default, nothing IDEA-specific). With the standard plan Starlink hands out one IPv4 address from **`100.64.0.0/10` (CGNAT)**, plus native IPv6 [16]. Public IPv4 is only an option on Priority plans [16]; IDEA does not need it.
- **CGNAT means no inbound connections** [16]. IDEA needs none: **Tailscale works through CGNAT**, because every device connects outwards and Tailscale traverses NAT or falls back to its DERP relays [17]. No port forwarding, no public IP, no dynamic DNS.
- **Pitfall: Tailscale's own CGNAT drop rule.** Tailscale addresses also live in `100.64.0.0/10`, and on Linux (OpenWrt included) `tailscaled` drops any packet from that range that does not arrive on `tailscale0` [18]. On Starlink the WAN DHCP server is in that range too, so DHCP **renewals** can be dropped and the WAN briefly drops every lease period. This is reported for OpenWrt and other routers behind CGNAT ISPs [19], [20]. **Decision D10 (closed):** the image adds a narrow exception — WAN UDP 67→68 accepted before the Tailscale drop rule, re-applied by a hotplug script because `tailscaled` repositions its rules [19], [21] (section 4.2 and customisation item 21). Option (b), the Tailscale node attribute `disable-linux-cgnat-drop-rule` [18], was not chosen. The test plan (9.2) checks that the lease renews.

12.4 When Starlink is down

- The **local network keeps working fully**: the Cudy, its Wi-Fi, DHCP, DNS (including `idea.local`), the firewall and all Engines do not depend on the WAN. Students and teachers keep the Console, Kolibri, Nextcloud and Kiwix.
- What stops: teacher internet (if switched on), Pi and content updates, Tailscale remote access and Atlas's fleet-health view of the school. Engines and the router reconnect to Tailscale by themselves when Starlink comes back; nothing needs to be done on site.
- The router's NTP keeps serving the last good time (section 5, item 8).

12.5 Power and UPS

- Starlink is the **biggest power user** on site: the Standard kit averages roughly **75–100 W** [14], against roughly 10 W for the Cudy (12 V) and 5–15 W per PoE Engine.
- A small UPS for the **Cudy, the PoE switch and the Engines** keeps lessons running through short power cuts; that is the part that matters for teaching. Putting Starlink on the same UPS shortens its runtime a lot for little gain (the school runs offline anyway). Recommendation: Starlink on mains (or on the UPS only if it is large); router + switch + Engines on the UPS.
- Starlink and the Cudy both come back by themselves after power returns; the Cudy keeps its settings, the WAN lease is renewed.

12.6 What not to change

- Do not turn bypass off, do not factory-reset the Starlink router, and do not plug school devices into it.

- Do not set a static IP, PPPoE or VLAN on the Cudy WAN; leave it on DHCP.
- Do not enable Starlink's own features that need its router (mesh nodes, its Wi-Fi) and do not add port forwarding or UPnP on the Cudy.
- Do not change the dish's mounting or move it without checking obstructions in the app afterwards.

12.7 Account and subscription (D11, closed)

Decision D11 (closed): the **IDEA project** owns the Starlink account and pays the subscription. The project holds the app login (needed for bypass, outages and obstruction checks). The school does not pay for Starlink. (4G remains a separate optional school add-on under D7.)

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